# Application Copilot: User Guide

Invest Detroit Real Estate/C&I In-Take Form · November 2026

## Quick start

**Link:** [ADD RENDER LINK] · **Videos:** [ADD APPLICANT VIDEO LINK] · [ADD STAFF VIDEO LINK] · [ADD 60-SECOND OVERVIEW LINK]

**Applicants:**

1. Open the link and fill in the form. The bar at the top shows what is left.
2. Stuck on a question? Press the yellow **?** next to it, or open **Need help?** at the bottom right.
3. Press **Review My Application** and fix anything under **Must fix**.
4. For each **Please double-check** item, fix the answer or press **My answer is correct: explain why**.
5. Press **Submit**.

**Screening staff:** read the **Application Copilot summary** that comes with each application before you start screening. Once a month, open **/insights** to see where applicants get stuck.

**Who to contact:**

- Questions about an application: the Invest Detroit team, info@investdetroit.com or 313.259.6368.
- Problems with the tool itself: [NAMED OWNER AT INVEST DETROIT].

## What it’s for

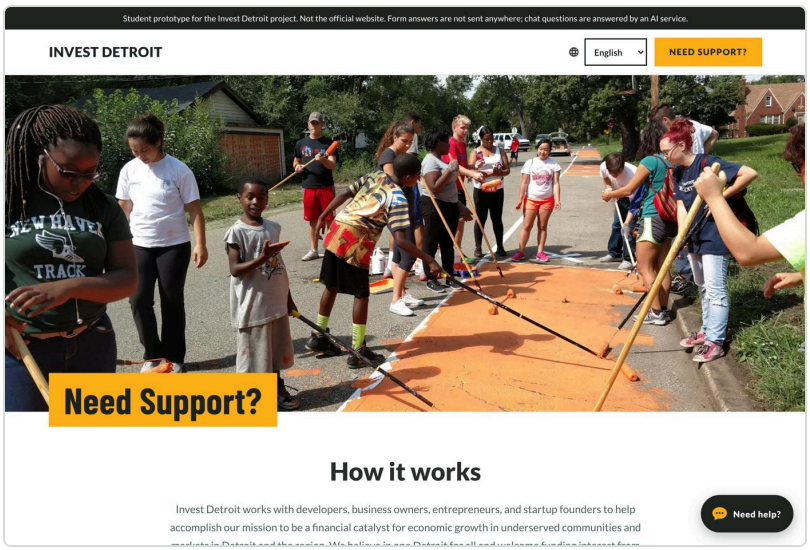
The copilot sits on top of Invest Detroit’s Real Estate/C&I In-Take Form. It helps **applicants** (developers and business owners) send a complete, correct application the first time. It gives **screening staff** a short list of what to double-check, so fewer applications need follow-up emails.

It explains, checks and points to sources. It never decides anything: approval, eligibility, rates and terms stay with Invest Detroit staff.

## Step by step: applicants

### 1. Open the page

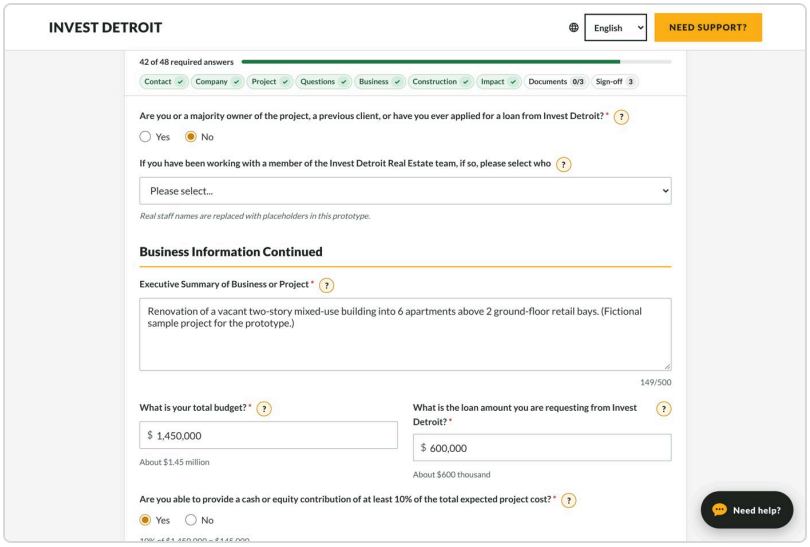
The page looks like Invest Detroit’s **Need Support?** page. **How it works** and **Before you start** sum up what you’ll need: the 3 required documents (project plan, development budget, team list) and your key numbers. Choose your language at the top: English, Español, العربية, বাংলা or 中文.




The page when it opens

## 2. Fill in the form

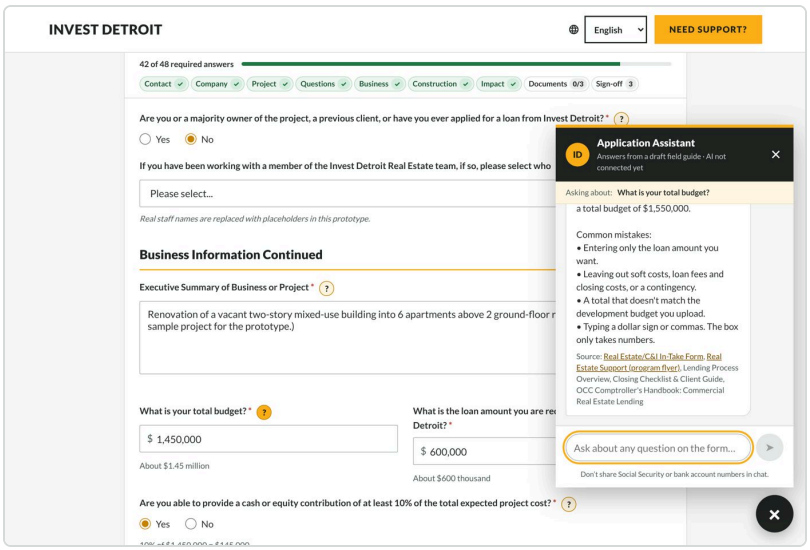
The bar at the top counts the required answers and shows each section. A green tick means that section is done; tap a section to jump to it. Dollar boxes add the commas for you and show the amount in words (“About $1.45 million”). Your answers are saved **on this device only** for 7 days, so you can come back later. The SSN box is never saved.




Form with progress bar

## 3. Get help on a question

Press the yellow **?** next to any question. The assistant explains the question, gives an example and lists common mistakes. **Source** shows which Invest Detroit document the answer comes from. You can also type your own question.



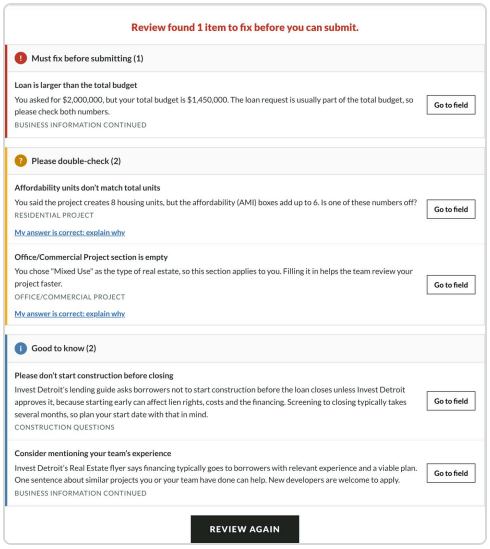

Help for “What is your total budget?”

## 4. Review My Application

When you’re done, press **Review My Application**. It takes a few seconds and shows three groups:

- **Must fix (red):** Submit stays locked until these are fixed. Example: a required question is blank, or the email has no “.com”.
- **Please double-check (orange):** these numbers look unusual but may be right. Fix the answer, or explain it.
- **Good to know (blue):** tips that never block anything.

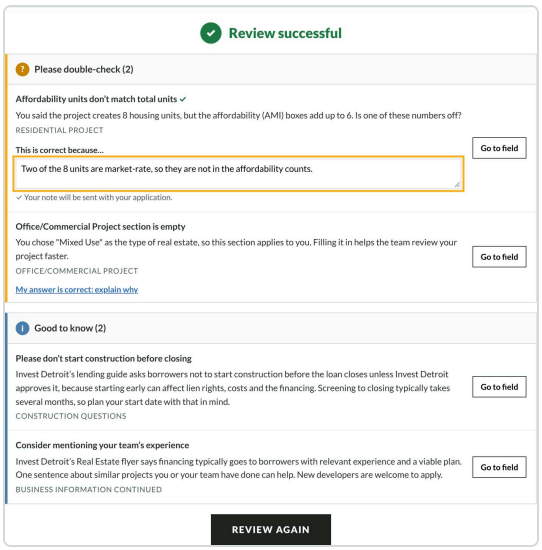
**Go to field** takes you straight to the question.




Review results

## 5. Explain an answer that is correct

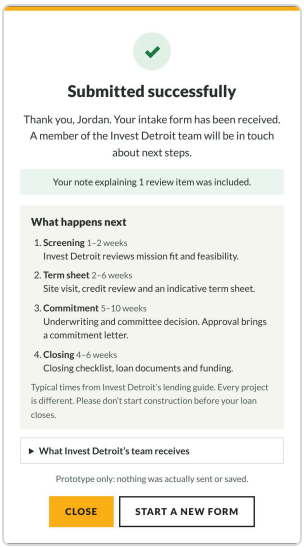
If a double-check item is actually right, press **My answer is correct: explain why** and write one sentence. The note goes with your application, so staff don’t have to email you to ask.




A note explaining a correct answer

### 6. Submit

Press **Submit**. You'll see **What happens next**: screening (1–2 weeks), term sheet, commitment and closing, with typical times from Invest Detroit's lending guide.




After submitting

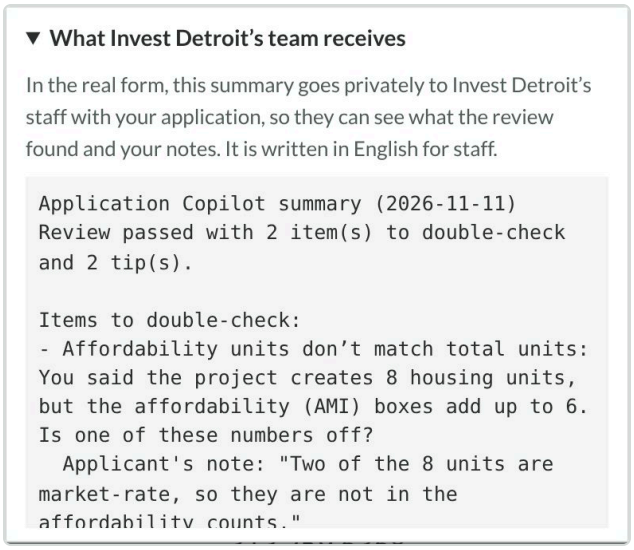
## Step by step: screening staff

### 1. Read the copilot summary

Every application comes with a short **Application Copilot summary**. It is always in English, whatever language the applicant used, and it never contains an SSN. It lists:

- whether the review passed;
- each **item to double-check**, with the applicant's own note if they wrote one;
- the tips the applicant saw;

- the language they used, if it wasn't English.




Staff summary

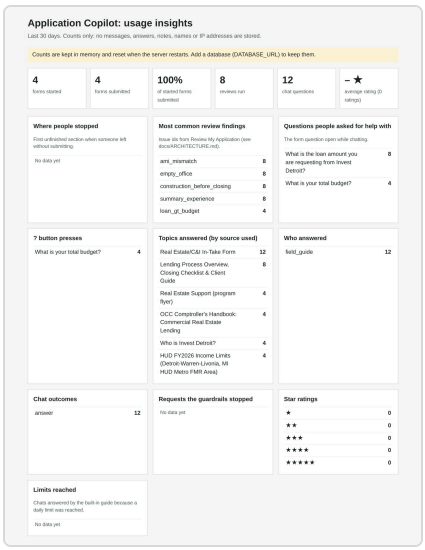
**What to do:** check each double-check item against the uploaded documents first. If there's a note, judge whether it explains the item. If there's no note, that's your first follow-up question.

## 2. Check usage insights (monthly)

Open **[site link]/insights** and sign in with the staff password (Render shows it under Environment, as `INSIGHTS_PASSWORD`). The page shows counts only, never names or messages:

- forms started vs. submitted;
- where people stop;
- the most common review findings;
- which **?** buttons are pressed most;
- chat topics and star ratings.

A question that gets many **?** presses, or a common finding, usually means the form's wording could be clearer.




Insights dashboard

## Understanding the results: one example

**Input:** the sample applicant (a 6-apartment mixed-use rehab with a $1,450,000 budget), with two mistakes added: housing units changed to **8**, and the loan request typed as **$2,000,000**.

**Result:**

| What the review said | What it means | What to do |
|---|---|---|
| **Must fix:** Loan is larger than the total budget | $2,000,000 is more than the $1,450,000 project. Usually a typo. | Correct the loan to $600,000. Submit unlocks. |
| **Double-check:** Affordability units don't match total units | 8 units, but the AMI boxes add up to 6. | Either fix the count, or explain: "Two units are market-rate." |
| **Double-check:** Office/Commercial section is empty | A mixed-use project usually has office or retail space. | Fill it in, or explain why it doesn't apply. |
| **Good to know:** Don't start construction before closing | Invest Detroit's lending guide asks borrowers to wait. | Nothing to fix. |

The staff summary for this application then lists the two double-check items, with the applicant's note under the first.

## What to check before acting on a result

- **Review results are reminders, not decisions.** A passed review doesn't mean the application is complete or eligible. Staff still read the documents.
- **Chat answers about Invest Detroit** (rates, fees, steps) come from Invest Detroit documents and show their source. Published ranges are "subject to change"; confirm current terms before quoting them to a borrower.

- **Uploaded files** are checked only for type, size and empty files. The copilot does not read what's inside them.
- **Applicant notes** are the applicant's own words. Verify them against the documents.

## Never trust it to

- decide or predict approval, eligibility, or a borrower's rate, fees or terms;
- judge creditworthiness, legal questions or tax questions;
- confirm that a property is inside Detroit city limits (use the City's Parcel Viewer);
- verify what's inside uploaded documents;
- replace a conversation with the applicant about anything unusual.

## When something goes wrong

| What you see | What it means | What to do |
|---|---|---|
| "I don't have an approved answer for that question" | The question isn't covered by the knowledge base. | Contact the Invest Detroit team (email and phone are in the message). Staff: tell the owner, so it can be added. |
| "I want to make sure I help with the right thing…" | The question was unclear. A known example: "My ZIP is 48212, am I in Detroit?" | Ask in other words, or press **?** on the question itself. |
| "I'm here to help you with your Invest Detroit loan application…" | The question was off-topic, or tried to change the assistant's rules. | Ask about the application. |
| "Applications need to be accurate and truthful…" | The question sounded like leaving out or changing information. | Ask how to report the figure correctly. |
| "That looks like a Social Security Number…" | Sensitive numbers are hidden and never sent. | Put sensitive details only in the secure form fields. |
| Answers are only in English | Claude isn't connected; the built-in guide is English. | The owner adds the Claude key (README). |
| Page takes about 30 seconds to open | The free hosting plan sleeps when unused. | Wait, or move to Render's paid plan (about $7 a month). |
| Review flags something that is right | Rules can't know every situation. | Press **My answer is correct: explain why**. |
| /insights asks for a password, or shows "not found" | It needs `INSIGHTS_PASSWORD` set in Render. | The owner sets it (README → setup). |

*Screenshots use the fictional sample applicant "Jordan Ellis". No real people or data appear in this guide.*